

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week 2: Lesson 3

Synthesis



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Synthesis means “drawing connections between ideas”. In writing, it refers to organising the information you’ve read or discovered and weaving it together into a narrative. It’s the ability to combine or contrast the views of others with your own



Synthesis



- Summary and paraphrase form ideas in your own words.
- Synthesis presents them with your voice.



According to Dale and Newman (2008) social capital is a required in order to develop communities sustainably. This is because social capital improves the connections between communities and external resources. Having said this, Dale and Newman (2008) note that social capital may be insufficient by itself. Governments also have a critical role to play. To illustrate the importance of government policy, Dale and Newman (2008) use the case study of a community initiative in a marginalised community of Vancouver, Canada.

This paragraph is NOT an example of synthesis?

It only cites one source.

Synthesis



Since social capital is differentially distributed, we need to understand the main factors that explain social capital inequality. As Newman (2011) suggests, social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks. According to the homophily hypothesis, “social interactions tend to take place among individuals with similar lifestyle and socioeconomic characteristics.” (Lin 2001, p. 39). In other words, networks of social ties tend to be homogeneous or assortative (Newman 2011) in terms of social attributes such as age, income, occupation, or education (Burt 1995). Moreover, the social segregation into clusters might be due to “systematic differences in the size of people’s social networks, across sociodemographic and socioeconomic groups” (Andersson et al. 2018, p. 103). For instance, Savage et al. (2013) show how individuals in the higher ladders of the British social structure have the highest values of social capital, compared to other socioeconomic groups.

This paragraph IS an example of synthesis.

It combines information from 5 texts.

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There is a mix of
integral / narrative and
non-integral /
parenthetical
referencing

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There is also
a mix of
paraphrasing /
summary and
direct
quotation

Effective use of topic sentences



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There is an effective topic sentence.

Effective use of topic sentences



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It’s good practice to begin a sentence with your voice

Effective use of topic sentences



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Rather than
someone
else’s voice.

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Also note: the writer follows quotes with a comment i.e. “In other words,...” and “For instance...”

Synthesis



You can find some examples of synthesis in the essay from Appendix A, Week One.



Synthesis: multiple sources



The assertion that institutions are the key to economic growth has been put forward by Rodrik et al (2002) and Acemoglu et al (2002). Rodrik et al assess the individual effect that institutions, integration, and geography have on a country's GDP per capita using regression analysis and contend that "quality of institutions trumps everything else" (Rodrik et al 2002: 4). On a similar note, Acemoglu et al also emphasise the institutions' effect, that is, the existence of "institutions ensuring secure property rights for a broad cross section of society" (Acemoglu et al 2002: 1235) will result in a better economic performance. By contrast, Sachs evinces his scepticism towards such arguments. Rather, he attributes Africa's persistent poverty to geographical factors such as its tropical climate, distance to coastal areas, prevalence of infectious diseases and scarcity of natural resources, thus suggesting that more foreign aid should be directed towards overcoming these geographical disadvantages (Sachs 2003; Sachs et al 2001; Bloom and Sachs 1998).

Synthesis: mix of integral and non-integral



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Synthesis: two quotations – mostly paraphrases/summaries



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Synthesis: connecting language



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On the next slide, there is a literature review paragraph by an LSE student, containing many effective synthesis strategies.



1. References from different sources
2. Generalisations ('scholars', 'recent research', 'the body of literature', 'academics').
3. Clustered citations (X, 2009; Y, 2014; Z, 2019.)
4. A mix of integral (narrative) and non-integral (parenthetical) references
5. Connecting language
6. Framing paragraphs with strong topic and concluding sentences.

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References from different sources



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Title: Artificial Intelligence in Radiology – An Affordance Perspective



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Task



- In groups, discuss the following question: “What do you think increasing automation means for the future of work?”
- Read the excerpts from academic articles about the future of work and note down the key points. In what way(s) do the authors agree and disagree?
- Read the comparative sentences and highlight any useful vocabulary.
- Then write a short, synthesised paragraph on this topic.

Text 1: Frey, C. & Osborne, M. (2017) 'The future of employment: How susceptible are jobs to computerisation?' *Technological Forecasting & Social Change*, 114, pp. 254-280.



While computerisation has been historically confined to routine tasks involving explicit rule-based activities (Autor and Dorn, 2013; Autor et al., 2003; Goos et al., 2009), algorithms for big data are now rapidly entering domains reliant upon pattern recognition and can readily substitute for labour in a wide range of non-routine cognitive tasks (Brynjolfsson and McAfee, 2011; MGI, 2013). In addition, advanced robots are gaining enhanced senses and dexterity, allowing them to perform a broader scope of manual tasks (IFR, 2012b; Robotics-VO, 2013; MGI, 2013). This is likely to change the nature of work across industries and occupations... According to our estimates around 47% of total US employment is in the high risk category. We refer to these as jobs at risk – i.e. jobs we expect could be automated relatively soon, perhaps over the next decade or two.

Our model predicts that most workers in transportation and logistics occupations, together with the bulk of office and administrative support workers, and labour in production occupations, are at risk. These findings are consistent with recent technological developments documented in the literature. More surprisingly, we find that a substantial share of employment in service occupations, where most US job growth has occurred over the past decades (Autor and Dorn, 2013), are highly susceptible to computerisation. Additional support for this finding is provided by the recent growth in the market for service robots (MGI, 2013) and the gradual diminishment of the comparative advantage of human labour in tasks involving mobility and dexterity (Robotics-VO, 2013).

Text 2: Spencer, D. A. (2018) 'Fear and Hope in an Age of Mass Automation: Debating the Future of Work' *New Technology, Work and Employment*, 33(1), pp. 1-12.



The advance in new digital and robotic technologies, it is claimed, will bring forth a future of less work. While history has disproved predictions of work's demise via automation, it is now argued that this time will be different and the days of work are numbered. Notably, writers from across the intellectual and political spectrum have seized on the prospect for the disappearance of work. Some worry about the negative effects on unemployment and inequality, while other more radical voices see the opportunity for a move beyond work and the creation of a world of abundant free time. In both instances, however, there is confidence that work will decline in the future.

This paper argues that work has continued to dominate human life, despite rapid progress in technology. Indeed, developments in technology are very likely to create more work for people to do. This is due to capitalism's tendency to use technology in ways that sustain and multiply work. While technology may evolve, there will be a tendency for capitalism to keep workers in work and to deny the extension of free time. The latest digital technologies are already being used to create a more disposable, insecure and exploited workforce. Their extended use in the future threatens to subject more workers to even worse quality work.

Text 3: Ford, M. E. (2009), The Lights in the Tunnel: Automation, Accelerating Technology and the Economy of the Future. Acculant: USA.



The economy will always create new jobs; we will never have structural unemployment as a result of advancing technology.

At present, I suspect that most economists would probably be likely to agree with this statement [‘the economy will always create new jobs’], and, therefore, disagree with what I have suggested in this book. However, I think we will end up with a serious unemployment problem. My argument is that accelerating automation technology will ultimately invade many of the industries that have traditionally been labour-intensive. Additionally, the process of creative destruction will destroy old industries and create new ones, and very few of these new industries are likely to be labour-intensive. As a result, the overall economy will become less labour-intensive and ultimately reach a “tipping point.” Beyond this point, the economy will no longer be able to absorb the workers who lose jobs due to automation: businesses will instead invest primarily in more machines. I also argue that this process will be relentless, and if it is not addressed by some type of government policy, we may ultimately see a precipitous drop in consumer spending as a substantial fraction of the population loses confidence in its future income continuity. That, of course, would result in even more unemployment and a downward spiral would ensue.

Read the sentences on the next two slides and highlight useful vocabulary.



1. Both Frey and Osborne (2017) and Ford (2009) predict that automation will result in significant job losses.
2. Like Ford (2009), Frey and Osborne (2017) suggest that large portions of the workforce are vulnerable to automation.
3. There is agreement between Frey and Osborne (2017) and Ford (2009) that automation will reshape traditional industries.
4. Both Ford (2009) and Spencer (2018) acknowledge that technological progress has major social consequences.
5. Ford's (2009) concern about inequality echoes Spencer's (2018) argument about the rise of insecure work.
6. Frey and Osborne (2017) and Spencer (2018) both recognize that technology is rapidly transforming the nature of work.
7. In a similar vein, Spencer (2018) also notes that digital technologies are being widely adopted in the workplace

1. While Frey and Osborne (2017) argue that automation will eliminate many jobs, Spencer (2018) contends that work will persist, though in more precarious forms.-
2. Unlike Frey and Osborne (2017) , who focus on job loss, Spencer (2018) emphasizes how capitalism adapts technology to maintain work.
3. A key difference between Frey and Osborne (2017) and Spencer (2018) lies in their expectations: one foresees decline in employment, the other a transformation in job quality.
4. In contrast to Spencer's (2018) view that work will continue, Ford (2009) warns of a future tipping point leading to mass unemployment.
5. Whereas Spencer (2018) highlights exploitation through work, Ford (2009) emphasizes exclusion from work altogether.
6. Ford (2009) takes a more long-term and systemic view than Frey and Osborne (2017), suggesting that even new industries will not absorb displaced workers.
7. While Frey and Osborne (2017) provide a detailed occupational risk analysis, Ford (2009) focuses on broader economic decline driven by automation.

Example paragraph



Automation is likely to have a profound and potentially disruptive impact on work, with varying interpretations across sources. Frey and Osborne (2017) argue that rapid advances in computerisation and robotics will place nearly half of U.S. jobs at high risk of automation, especially in sectors like transportation, administration, and services, marking a significant shift from previous automation trends that were limited to routine tasks. Similarly, Ford (2009) anticipates a long-term structural shift in the economy, warning that automation could lead to widespread unemployment as industries become less labour-intensive and fail to create enough new jobs to replace those lost—a scenario he describes as reaching a “tipping point.” In contrast, Spencer (2018) offers a more sceptical view of the automation-doom narrative, asserting that while technology continues to evolve, capitalism tends to harness these tools to intensify work rather than eliminate it. Whereas Frey, Osborne, and Ford foresee major job losses and systemic changes, Spencer emphasizes the persistence of work and its degradation in quality, rather than its disappearance. Taken together, these sources suggest that automation will significantly reshape the nature of work, but the extent and form of its impact remain contested.

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